Behavioral and leadership track

STAR stories, communicating technical decisions, influence without authority, mentoring and feedback, leading incidents, and growing into senior and staff scope.

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Contents

1. STAR stories and behavioral interviews (12 min)
2. Communicating technical decisions and design reviews (12 min)
3. Influence without authority (12 min)
4. Mentoring and giving feedback (12 min)
5. Leading through incidents (12 min)
6. Senior and staff scope and career growth (12 min)
Cheat sheet

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Lesson 1. STAR stories and behavioral interviews

12 minutes. Build a bank of specific stories using the STAR structure, answer follow up questions with numbers and trade-offs, and avoid the usual weak answers.

Behavioral interviews ask what you did, not what you know. Interviewers want evidence of judgement under pressure, and a small set of well prepared stories covers most questions.

What you will learn

- What interviewers look for
- The STAR structure and its common failure
- Building a story bank
- Adding numbers, decisions and trade-offs
- Handling follow up questions and failure stories

What they look for

Interviewers test for ownership, judgement, collaboration, learning from mistakes and impact. They listen for what you personally decided and did. A team result with no clear role for you tells them little.

STAR

Situation and Task set the scene in two or three sentences. Action is the longest part: what you chose, why and how. Result states the outcome with a number and what you learned. The common failure is to spend most of the time on the situation and then rush the action.

The story bank

Prepare six to eight stories that each fit several questions: a hard outage, a disagreement, a project you led, a mistake, a time you influenced without authority, a time you mentored and a time you made a trade-off with incomplete data. Write each as five bullet points, not a script.

Numbers and trade-offs

Say how many users were affected, how long it lasted, what it cost and what improved. Explain the options you rejected and why. Senior interviewers value the reasoning more than the success.

Follow ups and failures

Expect questions such as what would you do differently and what did others think. Choose a real failure with a real lesson, and describe the change you made afterwards. Avoid disguised bragging such as caring too much.

Diagram: STAR stories and behavioral interviews

Part	What it does	What goes wrong
Question	Asks for an example.	Vague.
Story bank	Matching story.	Too generic.
STAR answer	Action focused.	Long setup.
Follow ups	Probe your role.	We not I.

Flow: Question to Story bank / Story bank to STAR answer / STAR answer to Follow ups

Incident: The answer that said we thirty times

Incident: *A candidate described a large migration and could not say what they personally did.*

```
$ grep -o -i -w "we" answer.txt | wc -l
```

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```
31
$ grep -o -i -w "I" answer.txt | wc -l
2
(this is a simulated illustration, not a real incident)
```

The interviewer asked what the candidate decided and got a vague reply. The candidate rewrote the story with decisions in the first person: the cutover plan, the rollback criteria and the call to delay a week. The next answer was clearer and led to an offer.

Common mistakes

- Describing the team and not your own actions
- Long background and a short action
- No numbers in the result
- Stories that never show a mistake
- Memorised scripts that fall apart under follow ups

Check yourself

Which part of STAR should be longest?

Answer: Action

How many stories should you prepare?

Answer: Six to eight reusable ones

What strengthens a result?

Answer: A number and what you learned

How should you describe a failure?

Answer: Real cause, real lesson and what you changed

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Lesson 2. Communicating technical decisions and design reviews

12 minutes. Write short decision records, run effective design reviews and explain trade-offs to technical and non technical readers.

A decision nobody can find or understand will be remade every year. Clear short writing and well run reviews save more time than any tool.

What you will learn

- The decision record: context, options, decision, consequences
- Writing a design document that gets read
- Running a design review
- Explaining to non technical stakeholders
- Disagreeing and committing

Decision records

An architecture decision record is one page: the context and constraints, the options considered, the decision, and the consequences including costs. Store it next to the code. When a new person asks why, you can answer with a link.

Design documents

Start with the problem and goals, then non goals, then the proposal, alternatives and risks. Put a summary first, because many readers stop after a paragraph. Include a diagram and the rollout and rollback plan. Ask for specific feedback, such as risks you may have missed.

Running a review

Send the document in advance and ask people to comment in writing. Use the meeting to resolve open questions, not to read the document aloud. Separate blocking concerns from preferences, record decisions and name an owner for each action.

Non technical readers

Lead with the business effect: cost, risk, time and customer impact. Use one analogy at most, give a range with the assumption behind it and state what you need from them, such as approval or budget.

Disagree and commit

When the decision is made, support it even if you argued against it. Write down your concern and the signal that would show the decision was wrong, so the team can revisit it with evidence instead of feelings.

Diagram: Communicating technical decisions and design reviews

Part	What it does	What goes wrong
Context and goals	Problem and limits.	Solution first.
Options	Real alternatives.	Straw men.
Decision record	Chosen path and costs.	Not stored.
Review	Written feedback.	Meeting only.

Flow: Context and goals to Options / Options to Decision record / Decision record to Review

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Incident: A decision made three times

> **Incident:** *Two years after a database choice, a new team proposed the same change and the debate restarted.*

```
$ git log --oneline --diff-filter=A -- docs/adr | wc -l
0
$ grep -ril "why we chose" docs | wc -l
0
(this is a simulated illustration, not a real incident)
```

No decision record existed, so the context was lost when the authors moved on. The team introduced a short record template, wrote the missing record from memory and linked it from the repository README so the next debate started from facts.

Common mistakes

- Starting with the solution and no problem statement
- Straw man alternatives
- Reviews that read the document aloud
- Technical detail for an executive reader
- No record of the decision

Check yourself

What does a decision record contain?

Answer: Context, options, decision and consequences

How should review time be used?

Answer: To resolve open questions after written comments

What leads for an executive reader?

Answer: Business effect, risk and the ask

What does disagree and commit need?

Answer: A recorded concern and a signal to revisit

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Lesson 3. Influence without authority

12 minutes. Get cross team work done without managing anyone, by building trust, aligning on goals, using data and making the right thing the easy thing.

Platform and SRE engineers ask other teams to change things they do not control. Influence comes from trust, shared goals and lowering the cost of saying yes.

What you will learn

- Start with their goals
- Trust through small kept promises
- Evidence and a clear ask
- Making the right thing the easy thing
- Escalating without damaging relationships

Start with their goals

A team that is behind on a deadline will not welcome a request to upgrade a library. Learn their priorities and show how your request helps them, for example fewer pages at night or a faster release. If it does not help them, say so and agree on timing.

Trust

Do small things you said you would do, answer promptly and share credit. Trust is built over months and lost in one broken promise. Be the person who brings a draft pull request, not only a request.

Evidence and ask

Use data from their own systems: error rates, cost, incident counts. Make a specific ask with an owner and a date, and state the cost of doing nothing. A vague complaint produces a vague reply.

Easy defaults

Provide templates, libraries, pipelines and automation so the secure or reliable path takes less effort than any other. Offer to do the first migration with them. Adoption follows convenience more than mandates.

Escalation

Escalate only after a direct conversation, and tell the other person first. Present the problem and options to the shared manager, not the person. Accept that sometimes the answer is not now and plan for it.

Diagram: Influence without authority

Part	What it does	What goes wrong
Their goals	Learn priorities.	Ignoring them.
Trust	Kept promises.	Broken promise.
Clear ask with data	Owner and date.	Vague complaint.
Easy default	Template or tool.	Mandate only.

Flow: Their goals to Trust / Trust to Clear ask with data / Clear ask with data to Easy default

Incident: The mandate that nobody followed

Incident: *A platform team announced that all services must adopt a new logging library by quarter end.*

```
$ grep -rl "legacy-logger" services | wc -l
87
$ grep -rl "new-logger" services | wc -l
4
(this is a simulated illustration, not a real incident)
```

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Teams had no time and no help, so most ignored the mandate. The platform team then offered pull requests that did the migration for ten services, a codemod for the rest and a dashboard that showed adoption by team. Within two months eighty percent had moved.

Common mistakes

- Mandates with no help
- Complaining without data
- Escalating before talking
- Breaking small promises
- Ignoring the other team priorities

Check yourself

What should you learn first?

Answer: The other team goals

What makes adoption likely?

Answer: Making the right path the easy path

What should an ask include?

Answer: Owner, date and the cost of doing nothing

When do you escalate?

Answer: After a direct conversation, with options

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Lesson 4. Mentoring and giving feedback

12 minutes. Mentor engineers effectively, give feedback that is specific and kind, receive feedback well and delegate so people grow.

Senior engineers multiply their impact by growing others. That needs skills of its own: asking good questions, giving clear feedback and delegating with the right amount of support.

What you will learn

- What mentoring is and is not
- The feedback structure: observation, impact, request
- Reviewing code as teaching
- Receiving feedback
- Delegating for growth

Mentoring

A mentor helps someone reach their goals by asking questions, sharing experience and opening doors. It is not doing the work for them. Agree on goals, a regular time and what the mentee wants to practise. Let them find answers first and step in when they are stuck.

Feedback

State what you observed, the effect it had and what you suggest. For example: in the review you interrupted twice, so the quieter engineers stopped giving input, so please wait until others finish. Give it soon after the event, in private for criticism and in public for praise, and focus on behaviour, not character.

Code review as teaching

Explain the reason behind a comment and link to a guideline. Mark preferences as optional and separate them from blocking issues. Praise good solutions specifically, because people repeat what is noticed.

Receiving feedback

Listen to the end, ask for an example and thank the person even if you disagree. Decide later what to change. Ask peers and your manager for feedback regularly instead of waiting for a review cycle.

Delegating

Match the task to the person: stretching but possible. Explain the outcome you want and the limits, not each step. Agree when you will check in and let them make small mistakes. Credit them when it goes well.

Diagram: Mentoring and giving feedback

Part	What it does	What goes wrong
Goals	Agree what to practise.	No goal.
Observation and impact	Specific feedback.	Vague.
Stretch task	Right size.	Too big.
Check in	Regular and light.	Absent.

Flow: Goals to Observation and impact / Observation and impact to Stretch task / Stretch task to Check in

Incident: The review that stopped a junior from asking

Incident: *A harsh pull request review made a new engineer stop sharing work until it was finished.*

```
$ git log --author=maya --since=2.weeks --oneline | wc -l
1
```

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```
$ git log --author=maya --since=6.weeks --until=2.weeks --oneline | wc -l
14
(this is a simulated illustration, not a real incident)
```

The activity drop followed a review with sarcastic comments. The reviewer apologised, rewrote the comments with reasons and suggestions, and agreed a weekly pairing session. Commit frequency recovered within a month.

Common mistakes

- Giving feedback only at review time
- Criticising the person instead of the behaviour
- Taking over the task when the mentee is slow
- Delegating with no check in
- Never asking for feedback yourself

Check yourself

What does useful feedback include?

Answer: Observation, impact and a request

What is mentoring not?

Answer: Doing the work for them

How should preferences in a review be marked?

Answer: As optional, separate from blocking issues

What should delegation include?

Answer: The outcome, limits and check in times

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Lesson 5. Leading through incidents

12 minutes. Take the incident commander role, structure communication, make decisions under pressure and run a blameless review that produces action.

During an outage, technical skill matters less than clear roles and communication. A calm leader who structures the response shortens the incident and protects the team.

What you will learn

- The incident commander role
- Communication cadence and the status update
- Decision making under uncertainty
- Handoffs and fatigue
- Blameless reviews with real actions

The commander

The incident commander coordinates and does not debug. They assign roles: an operations lead who makes changes, a communications lead who updates stakeholders and a scribe who records the timeline. They decide when to escalate and when to roll back. If you are the best debugger, hand command to someone else.

Communication

Post updates on a fixed cadence, such as every thirty minutes, even if nothing changed. A good update states the impact, what is known, what is being done and when the next update comes. Keep a single channel for the incident and move side discussions elsewhere.

Decisions

You rarely have full information. Prefer reversible actions, such as a rollback or traffic shift, to risky fixes. State the hypothesis and the evidence that would disprove it, and time box each attempt. Ask the room for objections, then decide.

Handoffs and fatigue

After a few hours people make mistakes. Rotate roles, send tired people to rest and hand off with a written summary. A short break often saves more time than another hour of effort.

Reviews

A blameless review asks how the system allowed this to happen, not who caused it. Write the timeline, contributing factors and what went well. Produce a small number of actions with owners and dates and track them to completion.

Diagram: Leading through incidents

Part	What it does	What goes wrong
Incident commander	Coordinates.	Debugging instead.
Operations lead	Makes changes.	Unannounced changes.
Communications lead	Updates stakeholders.	Silence.
Blameless review	Actions and owners.	No follow up.

Flow: Incident commander to Operations lead / Incident commander to Communications lead / Operations lead to Blameless review

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Incident: An incident with three people debugging and nobody talking

Incident: *For two hours no update went to customers or to management.*

```
$ grep -c "STATUS UPDATE" incident-4821.log
0
$ grep -c "rolled back" incident-4821.log
1
(this is a simulated illustration, not a real incident)
```

Everyone was working on the fix and nobody had the communication role. A commander was named, updates went out every thirty minutes and a rollback that had been delayed was done within ten minutes of the decision.

Common mistakes

- The commander debugging as well
- No fixed update cadence
- Risky fixes before a rollback
- No handoff when tired
- Review that blames a person

Check yourself

What does the incident commander do?

Answer: Coordinates the response and assigns roles

What should an update contain?

Answer: Impact, current state, actions and next update time

Which action is usually preferred first?

Answer: A reversible one such as rollback

What makes a review blameless?

Answer: It examines the system, not the person

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Lesson 6. Senior and staff scope and career growth

12 minutes. Understand how expectations change from senior to staff and beyond, choose work that grows scope, build visibility and plan your own growth.

Promotion is not only about doing more of the same. Expectations change from solving problems to choosing problems, and from your own output to the output of many.

What you will learn

- The shape of senior and staff roles
- Scope: from tasks to problems to strategy
- Choosing high leverage work
- Visibility and sponsorship
- A personal growth plan

Roles

A senior engineer delivers complex work independently and improves the team. A staff engineer is trusted with ambiguous, cross team problems and sets technical direction. Titles vary by company, so read your own ladder and ask your manager for examples of strong cases.

Scope

Early in a career you are given tasks. Later you are given problems and decide the tasks. At staff level you may define the problem itself, such as reducing deployment time across the company. Each step needs more written communication and more work through others.

High leverage work

Look for work that many people reuse or that removes a recurring pain: a tool, a standard, a clear document or a hard migration. Say no to work that fills your calendar but changes nothing. Measure impact by time saved, incidents avoided or risk removed.

Visibility and sponsorship

Write short summaries of what you did and its effect, share them with your manager and peers, and speak at internal events. A sponsor is someone senior who speaks for you when you are not in the room. Earn it with reliable results and ask directly for stretch opportunities.

Growth plan

Pick one or two skills for the next six months, such as writing design documents or leading incidents. Ask for the project that requires them, find a mentor who is good at it and review progress monthly. Keep a record of your results for performance reviews and for interviews.

Diagram: Senior and staff scope and career growth

Part	What it does	What goes wrong
Tasks	Given to you.	Staying here.
Problems	You choose tasks.	Unclear goal.
Direction	You define problems.	No buy in.
Impact record	Written results.	No evidence.

Flow: Tasks to Problems / Problems to Direction / Direction to Impact record

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Incident: The engineer who worked hard and was not promoted

> **Incident:** *A strong engineer delivered many tickets for two years and was told they were not ready for staff.*

```
$ git shortlog -sn --since=2.years | head -2
  612 devon
  118 priya
$ grep -c "cross-team" brag-doc.md
0
(this is a simulated illustration, not a real incident)
```

Devon was the top contributor, but all the work stayed inside one team and none of it was written up. After talking to their manager they picked a cross team reliability project, wrote a design document, kept an impact record and were promoted the following year.

Common mistakes

- Waiting to be noticed
- Measuring by volume of tickets
- Work that no one else reuses
- No sponsor
- No written record of impact

Check yourself

What changes at staff level?

Answer: You choose and shape the problems

Which work has high leverage?

Answer: Tools and standards many teams reuse

What is a sponsor?

Answer: A senior person who advocates for you

Why keep an impact record?

Answer: It supports reviews, promotion and interviews

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Cheat sheet: Behavioral and leadership

STAR answers, decision records and feedback shapes.

STAR answer shape

Part	Content
Situation	The context in two sentences
Task	What you were responsible for
Action	What you did, using I not we
Result	A measured outcome and a lesson

Decision record

Section	Question
Context	What problem and constraints?
Options	What did we consider?
Decision	What did we choose?
Consequences	What gets easier and harder?

Feedback

Step	Example
Behaviour	In the review on Tuesday you interrupted twice
Impact	The team stopped sharing ideas
Request	Please let others finish

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